the face of it, the proposal appeared ridiculous and Sorabji was once again in the line of fire. ‘In the manner of all those who foresee disaster Sorabji’s critics wanted their forecast to come true.’[9] Both Sorabji and the Tata Directors wished to avoid the stigma of failure but when Sorabji put forward his plan to Sir Dorab Tata, the latter was skeptical, and it required all of Sorabji’s powers of persuasion to convince Sir Dorab that his was the only way forward. Sorabji wanted to avoid a banking failure which would tarnish the image of Indian banking but the advantage which would accrue to the Central Bank in terms of prestige and material resources could hardly have escaped his notice. Also, a challenge spurred him on to higher achievements and no one would deny that the amalgamation of the TIB could be classed as a major challenge.

A part of the opposition came from the European management of the TIB who found the myth of their supposed superiority being exploded difficult to stomach. The European manager resigned and the amalgamation was completed in August 1923. Before that the shareholders had met on July 19, 1923, to cast 5.5 lakh votes in favour of amalgamation as against 259 votes against it. They also exacted one safeguard from the management: the Directors of the new bank would not be allowed to sit on the Boards of other banks. ‘Obviously interlocking directorates were an evil much feared even in those days.’[10] As we have already noted before, the bank began its operations in Gresham Building in the Fort area of Bombay. With expansion in its operations, it moved to Alice Building on Hornby Road (now Dadabhai Naoroji Road) in February 1915, and later to the Taj Building, similarly situated, in March 1921. In 1923 after the amalgamation, it shifted to the magnificent building designed by George Wittet on Esplanade Road (now Mahatma Gandhi Road) which had housed the TIB.

There is also evidence to show that Sir Sassoon J. David had wanted to form a syndicate to buy up shares of the TIB at ₹16 each. This would have earned the syndicate a profit of ₹30 to 40 lakhs and ultimately resulted in the liquidation of the bank. Writing to Ratanji Dadabhoy Tata on the subject on June 30, 1923, some three weeks before the shareholders of TIB met to vote on the amalgamation, Nowroji Saklatvala, a TIB Director observed: ‘SJ’s scheme was so manifestly for his own advantage and detrimental to the Bank’s interest that we threw it out and resolved to go to the